# Lesson 44: Concession, Counterargument and Hedging

*English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 5: Argument and Academic Style*

*Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 5.8 Writing Concession and Counterargument; 5.9 Hedging.*

## In this lesson

You will learn how writers explain other perspectives and respond to them with counterargument or concession, and you will analyze an article and a student paragraph that do this. Then you will learn hedging: cautious language that limits a claim. Hedging is essential when you report research findings in psychology, where one study rarely proves a general claim.

## Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Identify other perspectives in a text and the connecting words that signal a change of perspective.
- Explain the difference between a concession and a counterargument.
- Write a concession/counterargument paragraph in three parts.
- Recognize hedging language and use it to qualify claims about evidence and research findings.

## Key language

| Word or phrase | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| counterargument (refutation) | a response showing that the other position is wrong | Nevertheless, … / Even if this is true, … / This may be true, but… |
| con·CES·sion | admitting that the other position is a little bit true, while showing that overall you are still right | Granted, boycotts have sometimes been an effective tool for reducing worker exploitation in other industries. |
| nuanced | not simply for or against; showing small but important differences | If you have a more nuanced thesis, it might be harder to think of what the other perspectives are. |
| Granted, / Admittedly, / It's true that | signal a concession | Admittedly, many human rights advocates have called for boycotts. |
| HEDG·ing | cautious language that limits a claim and shows some uncertainty | We use cautious language to limit, or put a fence around, our arguments. |
| qualify (a claim) | limit a claim so that it is less absolute | Here are some words you can use to qualify your claims. |
| overstatement | a claim that says more than the evidence shows | "Teenagers buy too much disposable clothing" is an overstatement. |

| Word or phrase | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| suggest / indicate | hedging verbs for reporting research | The results of the study suggest that people are more willing to shop ethically if their friends do. |

## Rules and explanations

### Joining the "Great Conversation"

Every article or book is one turn in a huge, timeless discussion in which writers build on and argue with each other's ideas. When you write a paper, you join it: you support your own position (your perspective, or point of view) with evidence, and you also explain other perspectives and respond to them.

### Which perspectives should you include?

- With a controversial topic, the other side may be the opposite. Thesis: *The government should strengthen regulations on water pollution from factories*. Opposite perspective: *Opponents of this plan argue that regulations are not an effective way to reduce pollution*.
- With a nuanced thesis, other perspectives are not always opposite. Thesis: *Although labor conditions in sweatshops are clearly human rights violations that demand international action, boycotts are actually not the most effective strategy to improve the situation*. Another perspective: *Granted, boycotts have sometimes been an effective tool for reducing worker exploitation in other industries*.
- Ask: Who disagrees, and why? Are they credible, and is their evidence solid? Do any facts contradict my idea? What are its drawbacks, limits and exceptions? If my idea is so great, why isn't everyone already doing it?

### Why and where?

- Explaining other sides builds ethos and logos. You tell the reader: "I already thought about the other sides. Here's what my opponents say, and here's why I'm still right!"
- Journalistic articles often move back and forth between perspectives. A U.S. college argumentative essay usually has one or more separate paragraphs for them: **first** (before your reasons), **last** (before the conclusion), or **next to** the body paragraph they relate to. The introduction should mention that other perspectives exist.

### The concession/counterargument paragraph

- **Counterargument:** the other position is wrong.
- **Concession:** the other position is a little bit true, but overall I'm still right.
- You can use one strategy or both. Connecting words show which side you are on and when you change sides.

| Part | What to write | Possible language |
|---|---|---|
| 1. Topic sentence (1+ sentences) | the other perspective: an opposite idea, a concern, an exception, or "Why isn't everyone already doing it?" | Some argue that... / Opponents of [my idea] argue that... / Skeptics of [my idea] contend that... / It's true that... / Granted, ... |
| 2. Evidence (2+ sentences) | why they think this, a quotation or paraphrase, specific details; explain their view fairly | According to... / They cite research showing that... / It's understandable that people worry about... |
| 3. Response (2+ sentences) | the other view is not true, is biased, uses a fallacy, is true but not important or not worth the cost, or actually supports your side | However, ... / Nevertheless, ... / This may be true, but... / Even if this is true, ... / Although X is a concern, ultimately... |

### Hedging

Hedging is cautious language that makes a claim more neutral and shows some uncertainty. It matters most when you interpret evidence and discuss its implications. Compare:

- No hedging: *The research clearly shows that ... shoppers must immediately eliminate all purchases from ethically questionable companies*.
- Hedging: *The research indicates that ... shoppers should consider reducing purchases from ethically questionable companies*. (This one is more likely to be completely true.)

Hedging builds ethos (your claims rest on a limited number of sources, and you show that you know it), makes your claims harder to attack ("In general, many teenagers buy too much disposable clothing"), and fits academic conventions. Hedges are small concessions inside your sentences, and they are still precise: they are not "muddy" phrases such as "in my personal opinion."

| Type | Hedging words | Example from the book |
|---|---|---|
| verbs | appear, suggest, indicate, tend to, seem to | The results of the study suggest that people are more willing to shop ethically if their friends do. |
| modal verbs | can, could, may, might, should | While it may be true that workers are at a disadvantage, conditions are improving. |
| adjectives | likely, unlikely, possible, probable, some, many, most | It is likely that the contaminants in the rivers are contributing to chronic diseases. |
| adverbs | somewhat, perhaps, probably, generally, typically, often, relatively, usually | Quality of life generally improves for every additional salary dollar workers gain. |
| there is a + noun | There is a possibility / a high probability that... | There is a possibility that more sustainable textile crops will be grown to match consumer demand. |

**In psychology:** research findings are almost always hedged, because a study measures a sample of participants and cannot prove a general law. Write "The results suggest that..." or "X is associated with Y," not "The study proves that..."

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Formal Arabic often uses emphatic words (often translated as "indeed" or "certainly"). Translated directly into an English academic claim ("It is certain that...", "without any doubt"), they sound overconfident. Use a hedge instead.

## Practice

**Exercise 1: Noticing multiple perspectives.** Read "'Plastic-free' fashion is not as clean or green as it seems" in the lesson material.

1. What is the writers' thesis?
2. What other positions do they explain and then fight back against?
3. Where do the writers shift perspectives, and which connecting words signal the change?

**Exercise 2: Concession/counterargument in action.** Read the paragraph from the student essay in the lesson material (it begins "Despite the clear injustices of garment production"). The essay's thesis is: *Although some defend the fast fashion industry's aesthetic and economic contributions, it has devastating impacts on labor rights and the environment, and needs serious regulations by all nations to stop the damage.*

1. What other position do the writers explain and then fight back against?
2. Where do they shift perspectives, and which connecting words signal the change?
3. Which parts are counterarguments, and which are concessions?

**Exercise 3: Noticing hedging language.** Read the three paragraphs "Unethical Amnesia" (from "Untrustworthy Memories Make it Hard to Shop Ethically") in the lesson material. List the examples of hedging language.

**Exercise 4: Adding hedging language.** These overstatements were made from other sentences in "Untrustworthy Memories Make it Hard to Shop Ethically". Rewrite each one with hedging language.

1. Our research shows that, even though all consumers want to buy ethically sourced items, it's hard for them to heed these sentiments.
2. When you buy a new sweater, you don't want to contemplate the harsh reality that it was made by exploited workers.
3. Consumers do their best to remain ignorant about whether a product is ethical or not, simply to avoid the anguish they would experience if they were to find out.
4. People always strive to act morally.
5. Consumers forget when products are made unethically so they can buy what they want without feeling guilty.
6. Shopping without a plan leads us away from our values.

## Speak with your tutor

- "Let's debate this thesis: [for example, 'Universities should start morning classes later so that students can sleep more']. You are a skeptic of my idea and give your strongest objection with

evidence. I will answer with a concession and then a counterargument (Granted... Nevertheless...). After five turns, tell me whether my concessions were fair, whether my counterarguments answered your points, and how well I used the signal words."

- "Here is a summary of a psychology study from my course: [paste]. Find any overstatements and suggest hedges. Also tell me where I hedged so much that my claim is no longer clear."
- "Here is my concession/counterargument paragraph: [paste]. Label each sentence Part 1, 2 or 3, and tell me if any part is missing."

## Read aloud

Pause at each |.

1. Granted, | boycotts have sometimes been an effective tool | for reducing worker exploitation in other industries.
2. This argument is compelling from a distance, | but even if it may be true to some degree, | it disregards the humanity of the garment workers.
3. The results of the study suggest | that people are more willing to shop ethically | if their friends do.
4. While it may be true that workers are at a disadvantage, | conditions are improving.
5. Recent psychological research suggests | that people experience "unethical amnesia".

## Writing task

Write a concession/counterargument paragraph of 150-220 words.

1. Choose a thesis: one from the book (boycotts and sweatshop labor; "natural" fibres; regulating factory water pollution) or a psychology topic, for example "Universities should start morning classes later so that students can sleep more" or "Heavy social media use harms teenagers' well-being."
2. Answer three of the questions in "Which perspectives should you include?" and choose the strongest other perspective.
3. Write the three parts: the other perspective, evidence for it explained fairly, and your response.

Checklist:

- Does Part 1 show clearly that this is not your opinion (Some argue that, Skeptics contend that)?
- Does Part 2 give specific evidence and explain the other view fairly?
- Does Part 3 signal the return to your position (However, Nevertheless, Even if this is true)?
- Is it clear which parts are concession and which are counterargument?
- Does your response show why your position is still stronger?
- Did you hedge claims about evidence (suggest, may, likely, tend to)?
- Are your claims still precise, without "muddy" phrases such as "in my personal opinion"?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

## Watch online

- "Hedging", a short chapter with more examples in Academic Writing I (UW-Madison ESL Program): https://wisc.pb.unizin.org/esl117/chapter/controlling-tone-through-hedging/
- The original article "'Plastic-free' fashion is not as clean or green as it seems" on The Conversation: https://theconversation.com/plastic-free-fashion-is-not-as-clean-or-green-as-it-seems-139082

## Answer key

**Exercise 1.**

1. Buying "natural" (plastic-free) clothing will not solve fashion's environmental crisis, because natural fibres also harm the environment and people; we need a radical change in how we make, buy and keep clothes (buy less, buy second hand, keep clothes longer). Key sentences: "However, the push to go 'natural' obscures a more complex picture" and "It is clear then that a radical change to our purchasing habits is required to address fashion's environmental crisis."
2. Any of these: natural fibres such as wool, hemp and cotton are the green alternative to synthetic (plastic) fabrics; natural fibres biodegrade; the industry's message that we can solve the problem by buying "natural" or "better" products ("buy differently, buy 'better', but don't stop buying"); certified fibres such as organic cotton and Woolmark wool are an improvement (partly accepted); emotive headlines that blame consumers of plastic-fibred clothing and tell them to "buy natural".
3. **However**, the push to go "natural"... / **While** they are presumed to biodegrade... / **However well-intentioned**, moves to find alternatives... / **Yet** the "better" and "alternative" fashion products... / (certified fibres are a welcomed change) **However**, they still contribute fibrous particles... / (discourses that blame the consumer) **However**, they do little to equally challenge...

**Exercise 2.** (book)

1. Some argue that the fashion industry provides work to people with few better choices in developing countries; Benjamin Powell says sweatshop labor is "part of the process that raises living standards."
2. **Despite** (first sentence) connects the paragraph to the ideas before it and signals that the other perspective comes after the comma; the next sentences (Vatz, labor costs, Powell) give evidence for it. **but even if** ("This argument is compelling from a distance, but even if...") signals the shift back to the writers' position. (The book's key also shows a sentence that is not in your lesson material: "**Granted,** moving textile production from the U.S. to developing countries created many jobs..." Granted is a typical signal of concession.)
3. Concession: "This argument is compelling from a distance" and "even if it may be true to some degree when we look at the history of economic development". Counterargument: "it disregards the humanity of the garment workers", explained by the last two sentences.

(The paragraph has no closing quotation mark after Powell's words; it should read: ...over time" (qtd. in Ozdamar-Ertekin 3).)

**Exercise 3.** (book) Perhaps, might, particularly, suggests, tendency, might, likely to, In general, should. (The key also prints prefer in bold, but without brackets; it is not one of the hedges.)

**Exercise 4.** (example answer: the article's own wording; other hedges from the table are also correct)

1. ...even though **most** consumers want to buy ethically sourced items... (also: many; Our research **suggests**...)
2. When you buy a new sweater, you **probably** don't want to contemplate the harsh reality that it **might have been** made by exploited workers.

3. Consumers **may** do their best to remain ignorant… (also: tend to do their best)
4. People **generally** strive to act morally. (also: usually, typically, tend to)
5. So, **maybe** consumers forget when products are made unethically so they can buy what they want without feeling (as) guilty. (also: Consumers **may** forget…)
6. Shopping without a plan **may** lead us away from our values. (also: can, might, is likely to)

## My notes